

GRE Vocabulary Notes: Group 24

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1. Assail

Meaning: To attack strongly with words or actions.

Tip to remember: Assail sounds like “a sail” hit by a storm. The storm attacks the sail.

Sentence: The critic assailed the weak arguments in the article.

2. Benevolent

Meaning: Kind, generous, and wishing good for others.

Tip to remember: “Bene” means good. A benevolent person has good intentions.

Sentence: The benevolent donor funded scholarships for poor students.

3. Berate

Meaning: To scold or criticize someone angrily.

Tip to remember: Berate sounds like “be rate.” Imagine someone rating you badly and scolding you.

Sentence: The coach berated the players for their careless performance.

4. Buoyant

Meaning: Cheerful and optimistic; able to float.

Tip to remember: A buoy floats on water. A buoyant person emotionally floats above problems.

Sentence: Despite the setback, she remained buoyant and hopeful.

5. Buttress

Meaning: To support or strengthen; also, a structure that supports a wall.

Tip to remember: Think of a support wall holding up a building. Evidence can also buttress an argument.

Sentence: The data buttressed the scientist’s conclusion.

6. Condone

Meaning: To accept, allow, or overlook bad behavior.

Tip to remember: Think of saying “okay” to something wrong. That means you condone it.

Sentence: The school does not condone cheating.

7. **Contravene**
Meaning: To violate or go against a rule, law, or principle.
Tip to remember: “Contra” means against. Contravene means to act against rules.
Sentence: The company contravened safety regulations.
8. **Denounce**
Meaning: To publicly criticize or condemn.
Tip to remember: Denounce sounds like “announce.” To denounce is to announce strong disapproval.
Sentence: The activists denounced the corrupt policy.
9. **Despotic**
Meaning: Tyrannical, oppressive, and using absolute power cruelly.
Tip to remember: A despot is a cruel ruler. Despotic behavior is ruler-like and oppressive.
Sentence: The despotic king punished anyone who criticized him.
10. **Deviate**
Meaning: To move away from the usual path, plan, or rule.
Tip to remember: Deviate sounds like “divert.” Both mean to move away from the expected direction.
Sentence: The experiment should not deviate from the standard procedure.
11. **Disinterested**
Meaning: Unbiased and neutral; not influenced by personal gain.
Tip to remember: GRE trick: disinterested does not mean bored. It means impartial.
Sentence: A judge must be disinterested when hearing a case.
12. **Escalate**
Meaning: To increase or become more serious.
Tip to remember: Escalate sounds like escalator. An escalator takes things upward.
Sentence: The small disagreement escalated into a major conflict.
13. **Exorcise**
Meaning: To drive out something evil, harmful, or troubling.
Tip to remember: In movies, priests exorcise demons. In GRE, you can exorcise fears or bad memories.
Sentence: He tried to exorcise his fear of public speaking through practice.
14. **Finicky**
Meaning: Very hard to please; too concerned with small details.
Tip to remember: Think of someone who complains about every tiny thing in food. That person is finicky.
Sentence: The finicky editor rejected the article for minor formatting errors.

15. **Foil**
Meaning: To prevent someone from succeeding; also, a contrast that highlights another thing.
Tip to remember: Think of aluminum foil blocking heat. To foil a plan is to block it.
Sentence: The police foiled the robbery before it happened.
16. **Intertwined**
Meaning: Closely connected or twisted together.
Tip to remember: Think of two wires twisted together. They are intertwined.
Sentence: Economic growth and energy demand are closely intertwined.
17. **Inundate**
Meaning: To flood or overwhelm with too much of something.
Tip to remember: Think of floodwater covering a village. Emails can also inundate your inbox.
Sentence: The professor was inundated with questions after the lecture.
18. **Ironclad**
Meaning: Very strong, secure, and impossible to challenge.
Tip to remember: Iron is strong, and clad means covered. Ironclad means covered with iron-like strength.
Sentence: The lawyer presented an ironclad argument.
19. **Jeopardize**
Meaning: To put something in danger or at risk.
Tip to remember: Jeopardize sounds like jeopardy, meaning danger.
Sentence: Poor preparation can jeopardize your GRE score.
20. **Mercurial**
Meaning: Changing mood or behavior suddenly and unpredictably.
Tip to remember: Mercury moves quickly and unpredictably. A mercurial person changes quickly too.
Sentence: His mercurial temper made him difficult to work with.
21. **Oblivious**
Meaning: Unaware or not noticing something.
Tip to remember: Oblivious sounds like “oblivion,” a state of nothingness. An oblivious person notices nothing.
Sentence: He was oblivious to the tension in the room.
22. **Perpetrate**
Meaning: To commit or carry out a harmful or illegal act.
Tip to remember: Think of a perpetrator, the person who commits a crime.
Sentence: The group perpetrated several acts of fraud.
23. **Plaintive**
Meaning: Sounding sad, mournful, or sorrowful.

Tip to remember: Plaintive sounds like “plaintiff crying.” Imagine someone sadly complaining in court.

Sentence: The singer’s plaintive voice moved the audience.

24. **Poignant**

Meaning: Deeply moving, touching, or emotionally painful.

Tip to remember: Poignant sounds like “point.” A poignant memory points directly to your heart.

Sentence: The movie had a poignant ending that made many people cry.

25. **Quiescent**

Meaning: Quiet, inactive, or at rest.

Tip to remember: Quiescent sounds like “quiet.” A quiescent volcano is quiet and inactive.

Sentence: The political movement remained quiescent for several years.

26. **Reiterate**

Meaning: To say or do something again for emphasis.

Tip to remember: “Re” means again, and iterate means repeat. Reiterate means repeat again.

Sentence: The teacher reiterated the importance of time management.

27. **Subside**

Meaning: To become less intense, less violent, or lower.

Tip to remember: Think of floodwater going down. It subsides.

Sentence: The pain began to subside after taking medicine.

28. **Subsume**

Meaning: To include something within a larger group or category.

Tip to remember: “Sub” means under. Subsume means to place one idea under a larger idea.

Sentence: The report subsumed several small topics under one main heading.

29. **Surmount**

Meaning: To overcome a difficulty or obstacle.

Tip to remember: Surmount sounds like “sir, mount.” Imagine climbing over a mountain; you surmount it.

Sentence: With patience, she surmounted many obstacles in her studies.

30. **Tangential**

Meaning: Only slightly related or not directly relevant.

Tip to remember: In geometry, a tangent touches a circle at only one point. A tangential comment touches the topic only slightly.

Sentence: His tangential remarks distracted the class from the main topic.